UNIVERSITY OF BIRMINGHAM

# Spatial Statistics for Decision-Making



## A Blackfly Tale

**Dr. Claudio Fronterre**

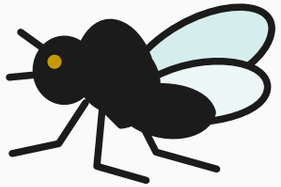
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**The Future of Parasitology**

12–13 October 2026

# Onchocerciasis

*Onchocerca volvulus* causes skin disease and eye damage, including blindness.



**Blackflies *(Simulium)***

Vectors breed in fast-flowing rivers

⇄

Transmission through blackfly bites



**People**

Infected people carry the parasite

> Repeated ivermectin treatment aims to interrupt transmission.

# What evidence supports stopping treatment?

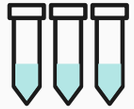
Evidence from people and vectors across the assessment area



**Epidemiological assessment**

Evidence of exposure to *O. volvulus* in children

**Ov16 serology**



**Entomological assessment**

Evidence of infective parasites in blackflies

**O-150 PCR pool screening**

Assess the evidence → Stop treatment when criteria are met → Post-treatment surveillance

# Collecting enough blackflies for assessment

**6,000**

blackflies for entomological assessment across a transmission zone

**Where should teams collect them?**

Field time and resources are limited.
Choosing where to allocate effort is crucial.

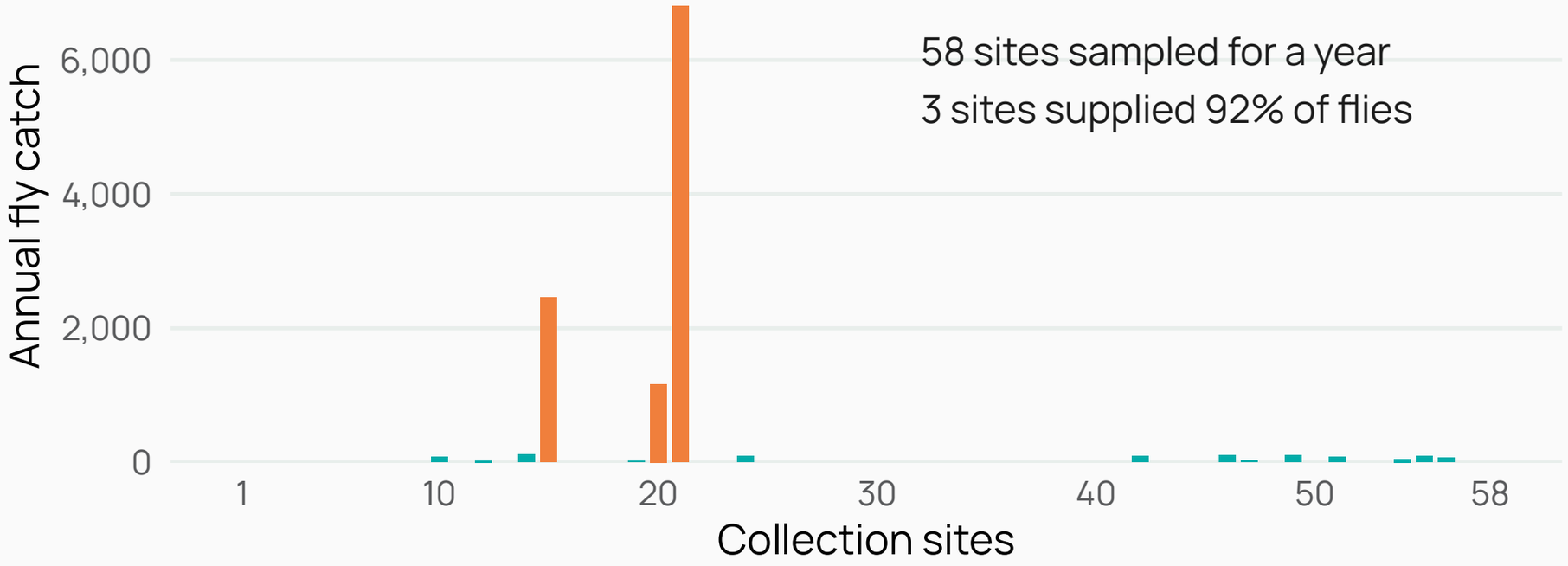
**Entomological threshold: <0.05% infective flies**

Upper 95% confidence bound · fewer than 1 in 2,000 flies
6,000 tested with no infective larvae detected provides the required precision.

WHO (2016). *Guidelines for stopping mass drug administration and verifying elimination of human onchocerciasis.*

# The problem that started this work

Anambra · 2021–2022 entomological assessment




FMoH / The Carter Center

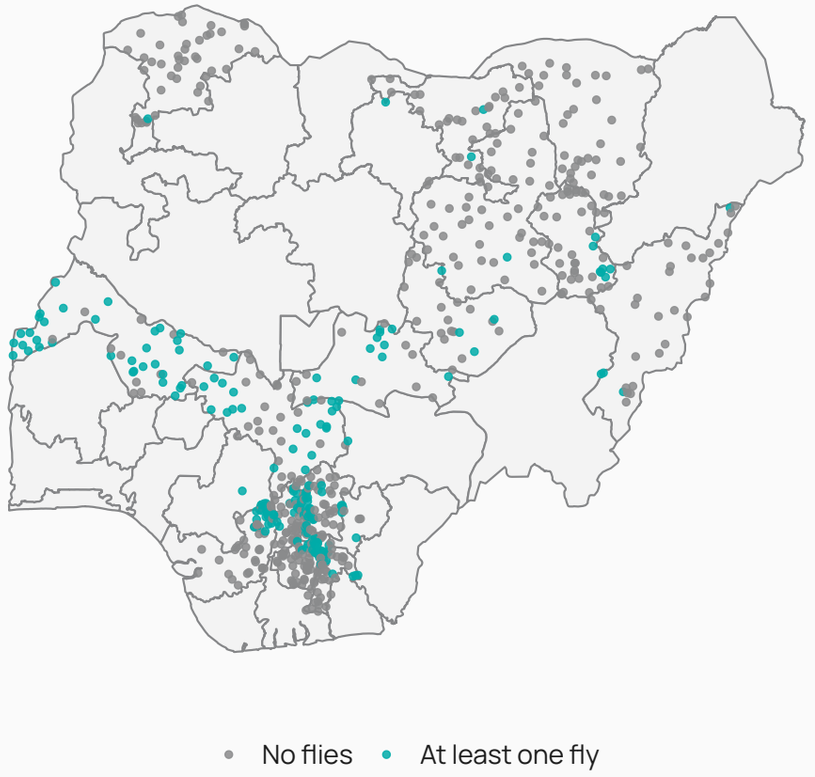
# The Nigerian data behind Blackfly Finder

**676** trap locations

**7,617** observed site-months

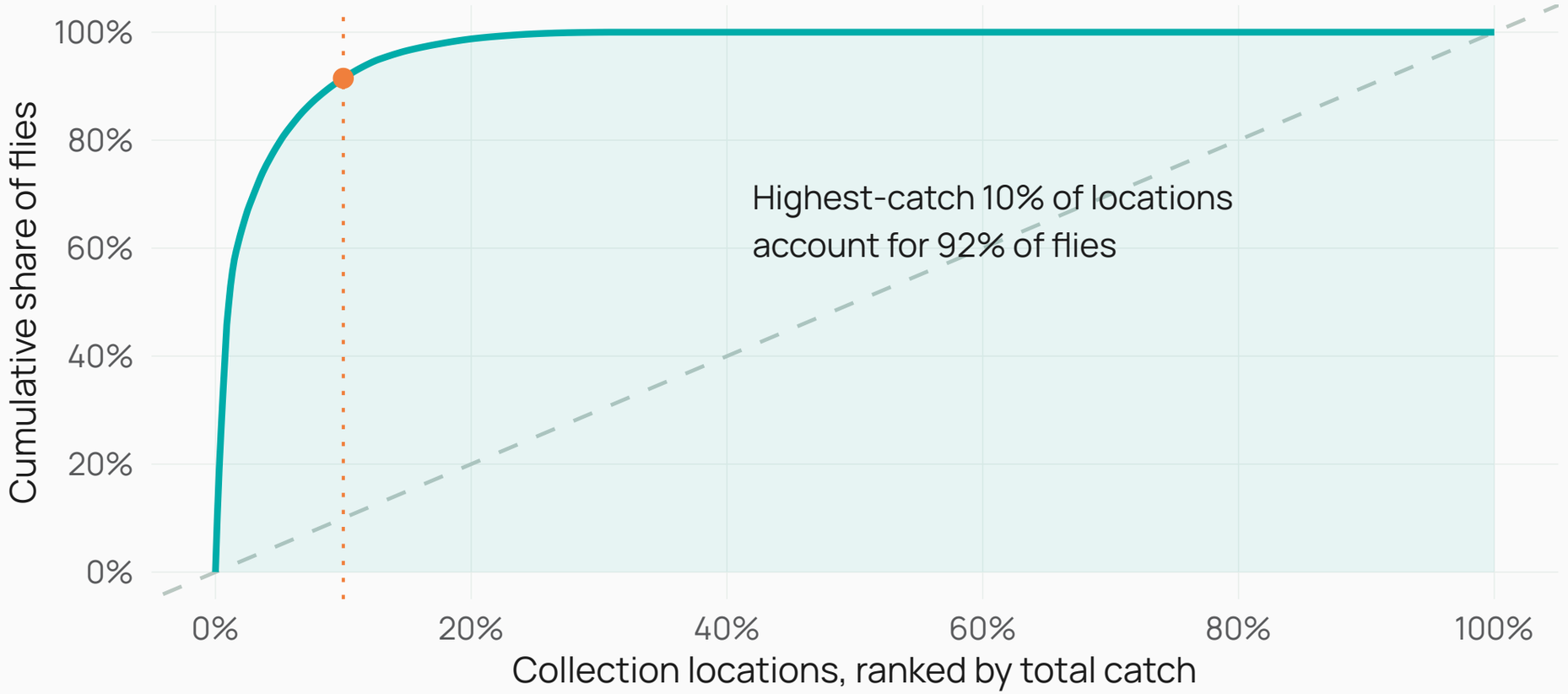
**2020–2025** monthly collection records

Human landing collections



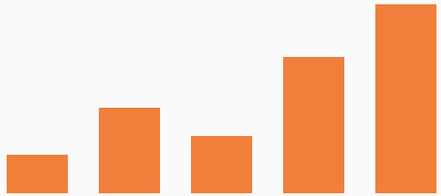

FMoH / TCC and SORT records

# Catch is concentrated in a few sites



# Blackfly Finder: a two-part hurdle model

0 / +



**Will we find flies?**

Probability of a positive catch

Ensemble of presence models

**How many might we collect?**

Expected catch when flies are found

Negative-binomial count model

**Expected catch** = Probability of finding flies × Expected positive catch

Allows for differences in observation duration.

# What informs Blackfly Finder?

### Rivers and terrain
Hydrology and landscape shape

### Climate
Temperature and rainfall

### Soils
Soil properties and temperature

### Land and vegetation
Land cover, population and livestock

## Presence / absence

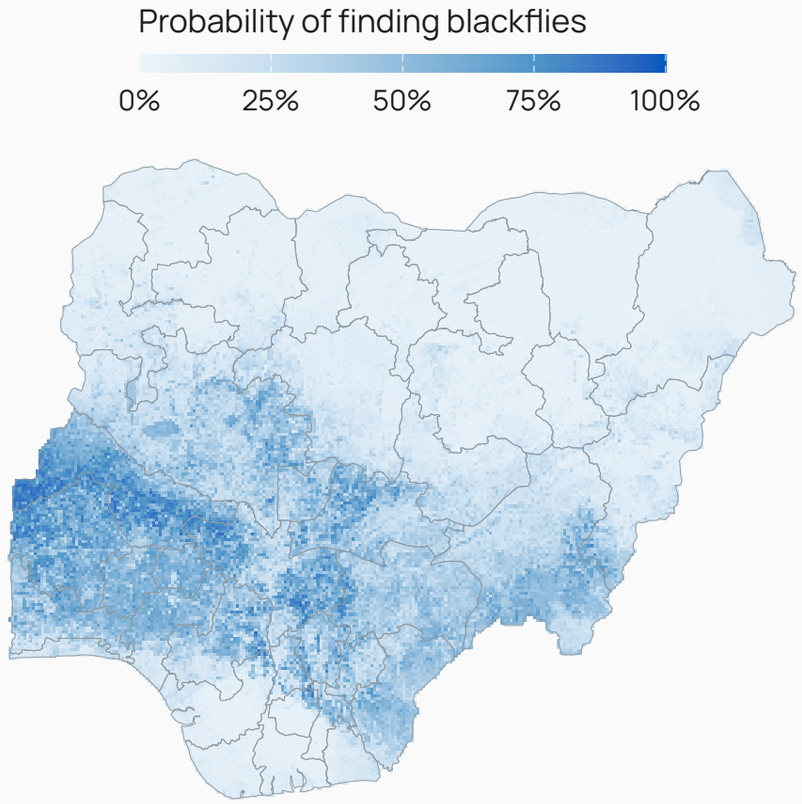
Environmental inputs combined in
an ensemble of presence models

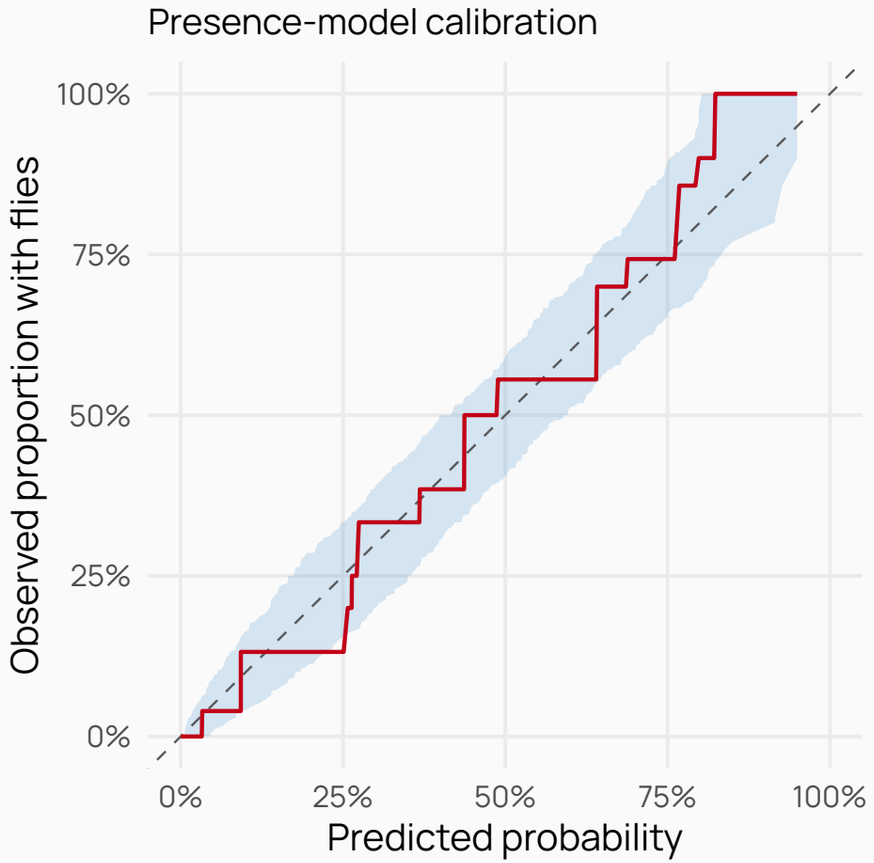
## Positive-catch intensity

Air temperature range · soil clay content
Soil temperature seasonality · terrain variation

Different predictors can explain where flies are found and how many are caught.

# Where should teams look for blackflies?




Cross-validated base predictions
Shaded 90% consistency band

# Where can teams collect?

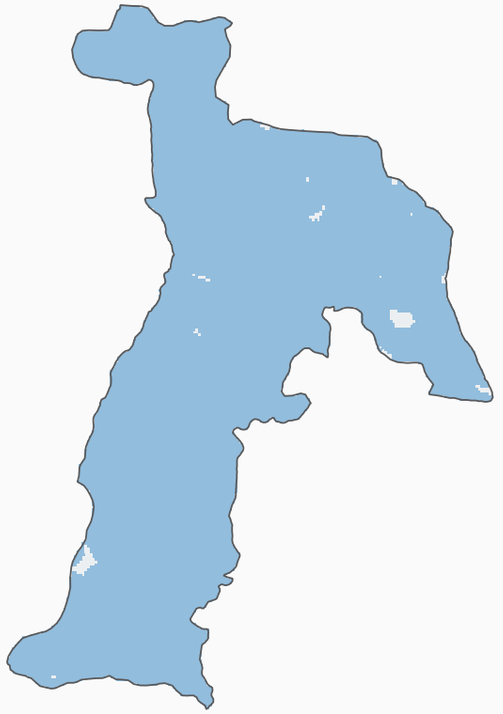
Define a feasible sampling region.

**5 km** from rivers

**2 km** from roads

**5 km** from populated areas

A location must satisfy all three access limits.



Abia · blue cells satisfy all three limits

Illustrative settings · teams can adjust the limits to local field conditions.

# Choosing sites within the feasible region

Abia example · 30 proposed sites

## Prioritise finding flies

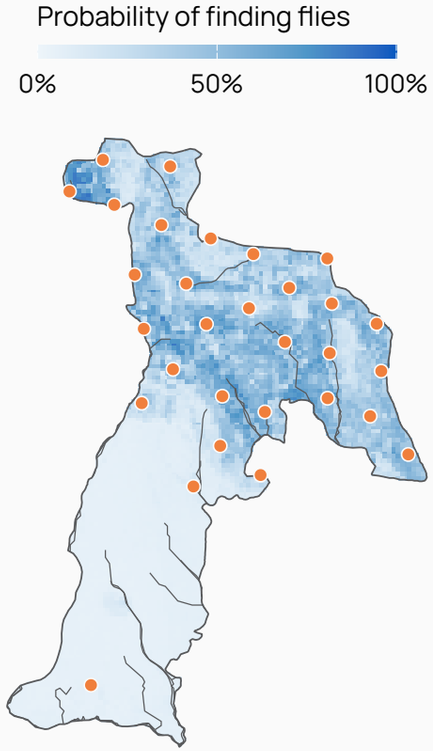
Rank feasible locations by their predicted probability.

## Keep sites apart

At least 5 km between selected sites.

## Check major-river coverage

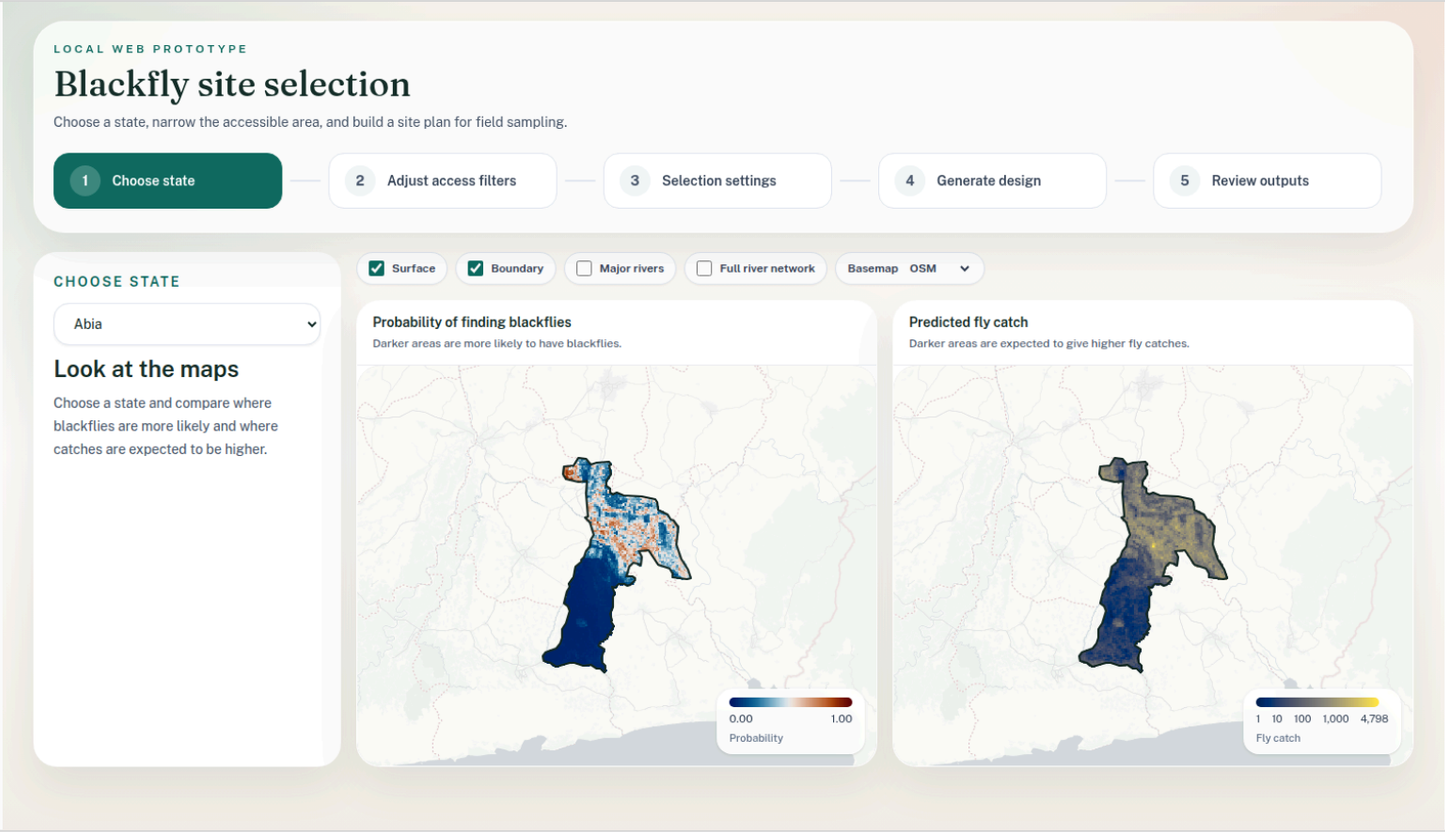
A selected site within 30 km of each sampled river point.




Orange: proposed sites · grey: major rivers

Proposed design for review · access, spacing and river coverage are checked together.

# A sampling web-tool teams can use




## 1. Set constraints

Choose the state, access limits and site spacing.

## 2. Generate and review

Inspect the proposed sites and coverage.

## 3. Download the plan

Export coordinates and the design summary.

# Could an adaptive strategy improve sampling?

Three monthly visits to the same site. No flies caught.

| Month 1 | Month 2 | Month 3 |
|---|---|---|
| **0** flies | **0** flies | **0** flies |

## Would you stay at this site, or move?

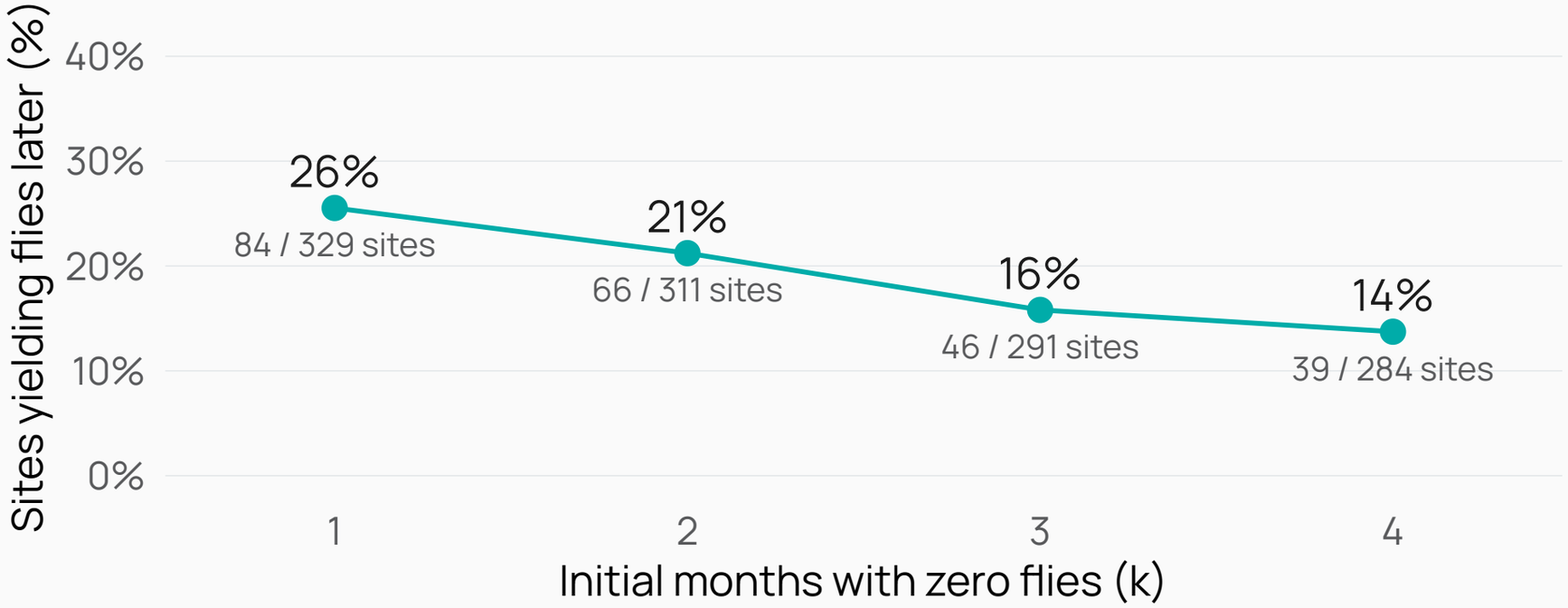
**Stay at the site**

A more productive season may be ahead.

**Move to a reserve site**

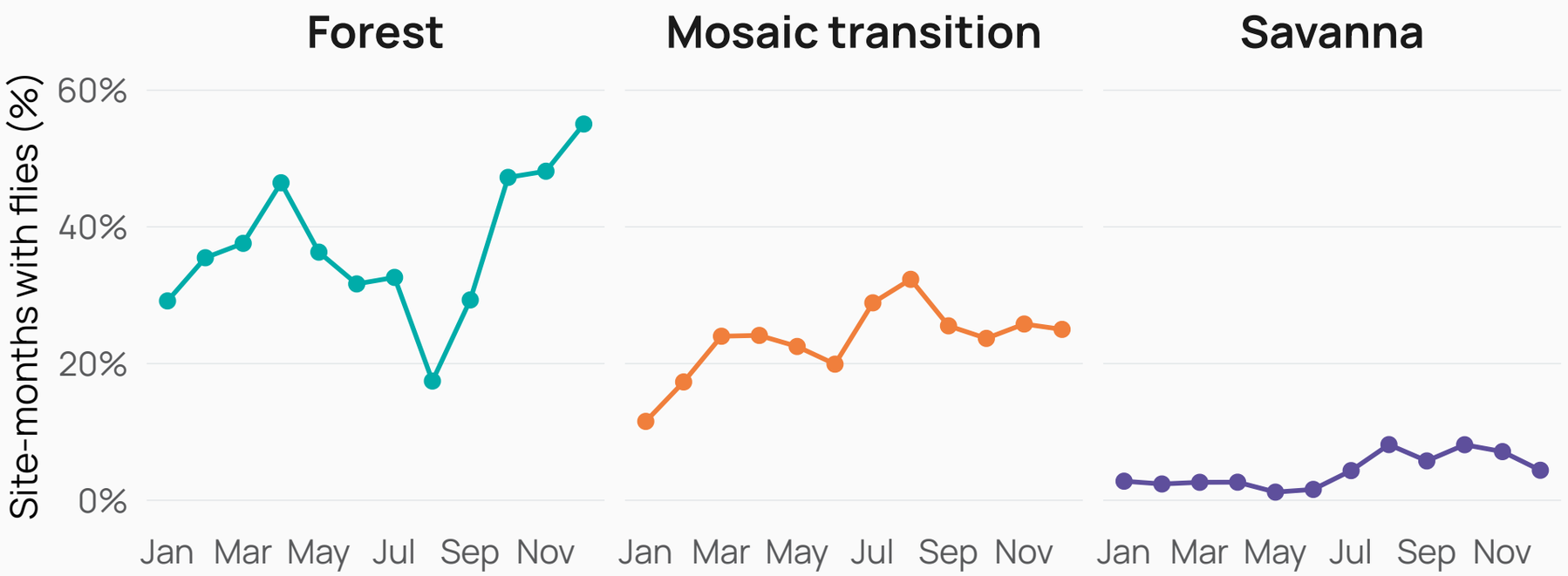
Another site may offer a better yield.

# What do repeated zeros imply?




After three zero months, 16% of sites yielded flies in months 4–12.

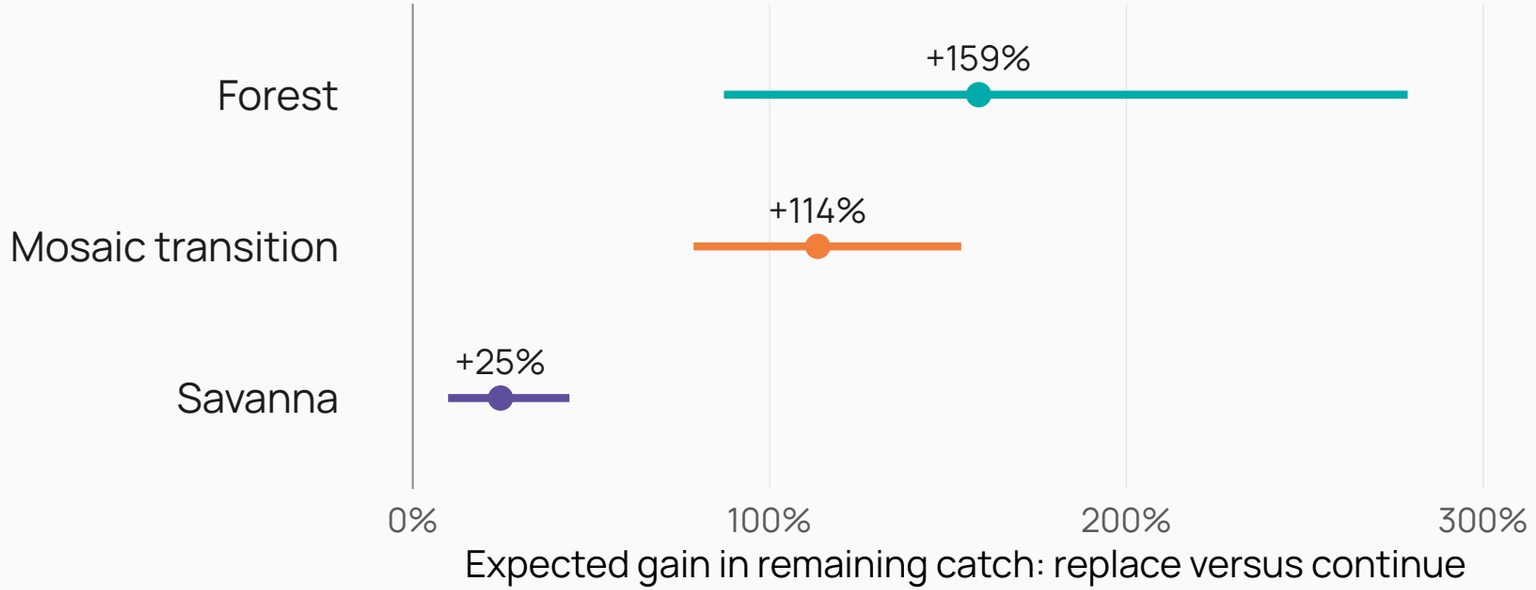
# Season changes the chance of finding flies




Repeated zeros need to be interpreted in their seasonal context.

# When could replacing a site improve catches?

After three zero months: compare the expected catch over the remaining nine months.




## The potential gain depends on ecological setting and when sampling starts.

Modelled scenario. Dots show the mean gain across start months.
Lines show the lowest and highest gains across start months.

# An adaptive strategy to test

**1** **Prepare original and reserve sites**

Use the same selection process for both.

**2** **Choose when to replace a site**

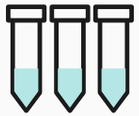
Compare **1–4 initial zero months**, accounting for season and start month.

**3** **Validate with parallel field sampling**

Follow original sites for **12 months** and sample reserves alongside them.
Compare fly yields over the same calendar months.

# From blackfly sampling to elimination assessment

Next research steps



### Test the collected flies

Use infectivity tests to investigate where infective flies occur.



### Combine human and vector evidence

Develop joint models of epidemiological and entomological observations.

Better sampling strengthens the evidence for elimination assessment.
Fly yield alone does not establish interrupted transmission.

# Conclusions

- **Spatial predictions** help target sampling within accessible areas.
- **Seasonal evidence** helps teams interpret repeated zero catches.
- **Accessible web tools** put sampling plans in the hands of field teams.

Next research steps

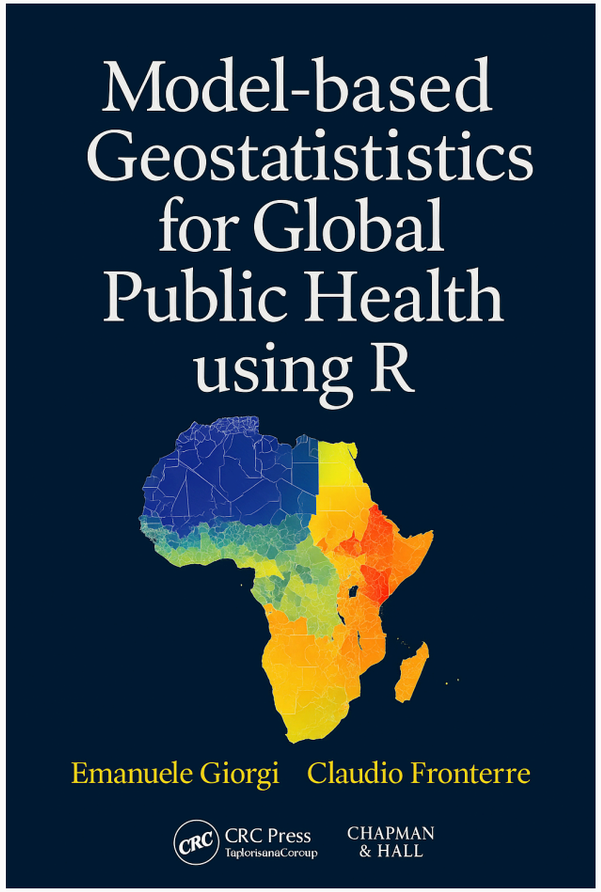
### Field validation

Test the adaptive strategy through prospective comparisons of fly yield.

### A joint epi–ento model

Combine epidemiological and entomological evidence to assess transmission.

# Coming soon: a new book




**Model-based Geostatistics for Global Public Health using R**

Emanuele Giorgi and Claudio Fronterre

A hands-on introduction to disease mapping with the **RiskMap** package and real-world case studies.

Read online at **mbgr.org**.

# Grazie!

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